

Q. How do you think open source has evolved since then?

A. I can say that, earlier, open source was a passion that fascinated and attracted people to participate. I was particularly impressed hearing user-friendly stories across the world when some Siberian contributors were working to improve water scarcity. It was more like a corporate social responsibility (CSR) activity. A board would be created by people and experts to govern and take projects forward. People would come in for the love of technology without expectations.

I did not believe then that open source could get commercial, but it is the driving force for most of the innovation and technology today, and many more enterprises are adopting it. We are looking forward to a great balance in contribution to and use of open source, as we have people, communities and big companies coming into play. This is the real future and power of open source.

Q. Could you share some of your challenges?

A. Initially, I walked alone but people joined once they knew my intentions were good. I created a lot of communities without any expectation, but did get paid indirectly in terms of reputation or fame; some people understood that I was a technical expert and gave projects in the long term. As it was very early days, people started joining the community and contributing without much effort. The goal wasn't to get business and hence I can say I didn't really face any hurdles.

Q. What are your leadership mantras and lessons from being a community leader?

A. First, if you want to start a community, then be neutral and don't harbour a biased opinion. It may look like you are running a community as a leader, but remember those joining you are contributing equally. And never

demotivate anyone. Be polite while making comments and addressing queries. Whatever the question, if you don't want to give an answer, then choose to be quiet. But don't stop anyone from asking. Help them build expertise.

Second, don't involve the community in business. Do not mix and match the goals of your business and community. Have a clear differentiation.

Always try to encourage people to participate instead of delivering instructions as an expert. If you find people are interested to lead and take initiatives, then give them the stage. Invite and engage them in the community. That will help you to make more community leaders. Also, keep your community simple and don't involve sponsors in the initial stages.

Q. Who do you look up to for inspiration?

A. Richard Stallman, the father of the open source movement, is my inspiration and I have always admired his projects.

Apart from him, I have an interesting incident to share that inspired me to work on open source. At the time when I started working on open source, most of the software for the Nuclear Science Centre was based on the Windows OS. However, many scientists wanted to work with Linux based software. And within two or three months, they actually created Linux drivers. This is what fascinated me – that the user can create these drivers which may not be possible in the case of proprietary software. I really liked the fact that open source empowered the user.

Q. Your thoughts on the open source landscape in India and the scope for improvement.

A. India is the largest consumer of open source and we are focusing on becoming a contributor. With so

many developers around, we still do not have software giants in India. What we have mostly are service providers and not innovators. More people should become contributors to open source and develop something with international labels.

The very thought of contributing to open source should begin from the level of schools and colleges. Fortunately, the Gujarat government has already introduced lessons based on Linux from Class 8 to Class 10. It is important to educate and make youngsters aware of open source models.

Second, we have to develop good mentors. When people start contributing, it is important to find an open source mentor working in that particular project. The mentor gives a small assignment, tries the code and then commits it. If everything goes fine, the contribution is increased gradually. Unfortunately, we have very few mentors available in India. We need to prepare a lot of mentors or maybe connect to those across the world.

Third, we need to encourage those who come forward to contribute. Once you are a recognised developer or a person contributing to open source development, you also progress in your career and business.

India can be a major contributor to open source by following such simple methods.

Q. What do you think about the coding requirements to contribute to open source?

A. From my experience, if you know the internal parts, how to develop the application, what code standard you should maintain, and how to manage the team and other best practices, you may not have to actually worry about coding expertise.

There are other roles too with respect to designing, security maintenance and integration. See what works for you. Develop and strengthen your skill in what you like